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Painting The Page Proper

As business becomes increasingly Web-driven, the Web designer's skills are playing a role larger than ever before

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In the early years of the development of the Web, sites were largely HTML-only. Then came Flash animation, JavaScript, Perl, Python, ColdFusion and more. When broadband became common, Web designers began to make Web pages heavier and more content-rich. And today, a lot of large, medium, and small start-ups are designing Web sites conforming to Web 2.0 standards. The role of a Web designer now encompasses more than ever before.

Good Web site design means appropriately laid-out content, working buttons and animations, and no glitches such as misleading links and distracting ads or pop-ups. Of course, there's more to it. But ultimately, information on Web sites helps consumers with purchase decisions, and a well-designed site appeals to customers, clients, and even potential investors.

Business undertakings have foreseen the potential of an online identity, and have started investing in that area to remain in competition.

"Ample opportunities lie in the industry today, both in India and abroad, but especially in India. There is a dearth of quality Web designers, and demand for them is growing gradually in the country. Businesses, both big and small, as well as individuals, want to have their own Web sites," says Deepak Bedi, project manager, eCreed's Creative Labs located in Mumbai, who are involved in Web design and other Web services.

Profiles

After the necessary education and the gaining of proficiency over Web designing tools, a number of specialisation options await budding Web designers. The design of a Web site takes place at many levels, but at certain times, roles may overlap: a graphics designer may also design the user

interface, depending on several factors such as the proficiency of the designer or the lack of a skilled person for the job. Also, one person can be an expert in Flash with ActionScript as well as other scripting languages.

Graphics Designers use images, colour combinations, animations, and other supporting elements for good presentation, navigation, and layout of the site. They create the visual feel to the site. A knowledge and expertise of the latest Web design tools such as the Adobe graphics suite, Flash, Dreamweaver, etc. is a must.

Interaction Designers focus upon human interaction with the site, and strive to bring out better solutions in terms of the user-friendliness of the design. They decide what kinds of animation should be placed, how navigation would be done, etc. Their work profile involves interacting with designers, content developers, programmers, the marketing team, and others. The designer then builds an interaction plan for the site and the functions offered, such that the goals of the client's business and the user's needs are met.

Working with wire-frames (visual guides to suggest placement of design elements and their layout), content flow, mock-ups (models that look like the real thing but without functionality), concept briefs, and conceptual models form part of their routine.

User Interface Engineer/Designers: The interface of the site is designed using scripting languages and other tools. The interface designer actually designs the interface layouts, the size, style, and flow of text, CSS (Cascading Style Sheets), and process movements, and uses scripting languages such as ASP, PHP, JSP, Perl, Python, etc. as required, for a better user experience. He also designs templates for the site as well as prototypes for testing. Designing a Web site that has a login option is more difficult, because the best measures to prevent ID theft, hack attacks, etc. need to be implemented.